

Fourteen Independent Thinkers, Read Side by Side

When serious independent thinkers seem to contradict each other, and the official story is often spin, how do you find out what is true? Read them side by side, check every quote, and test their explanations against the facts.

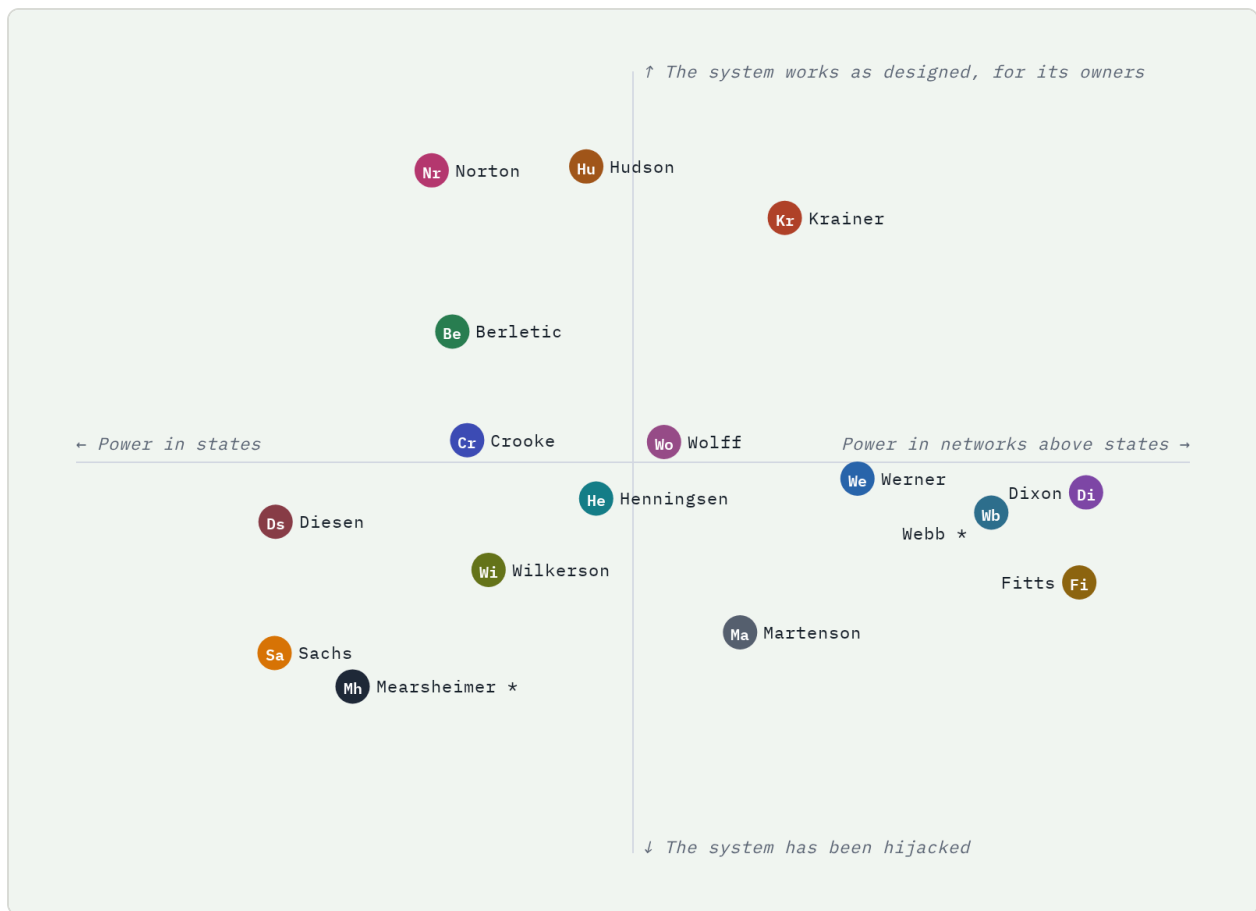
People who have studied the same subject closely often explain it in very different ways. How do you combine their explanations into one picture you can trust, when the official version cannot be taken at face value? This article shows one way to do it, step by step.

The subject I chose is the US empire: who controls it, how it works, and why it goes to war. It makes a good test for two reasons. Sixteen independent thinkers I follow have all discussed it, from Michael Hudson, who says creditors capture governments, to Simon Dixon, who says there is no one at the top at all. And deception is part of the subject: a war can be made to look like someone else's.

Doing this means reading all of them in their own words and comparing them claim by claim, which used to take a research team. I did it with an AI, which read the material, built the comparisons and checked every quotation against the original texts, while I corrected it where it misread people.

The method has seven steps. Each one below says what it does, then what it found about US power.

The full charts are at christiancadieux.github.io/fourteen-thinkers/author-axes.html, and the full written synthesis, with every source, is on [GitHub](#).



The sixteen on one map, with authors of similar views close together. Left to right: power in states, then power in networks above states. Bottom to top: the system has been hijacked, by a lobby or by a control grid, then the system works as designed, for its owners. An asterisk marks authors with several missing scores, whose positions are rougher. How the map is built, and what drives each axis, is on the [charts page](#).

The group

The group: Richard Werner, Alex Krainer, Brian Berletic, Simon Dixon, Catherine Austin Fitts, Ben Norton, Patrick Henningsen, Chris Martenson, Michael Hudson, Alastair Crooke, Lawrence Wilkerson, Glenn Diesen, Whitney Webb, Richard Wolff, John Mearsheimer and Jeffrey Sachs.

I chose them for a shared quality: none of them speaks for a government or a party line. Beyond that they differ a lot. Werner is an economist known for his work on how banks create money. Fitts was an assistant secretary of housing and a Wall Street banker. Wilkerson was Colin Powell's chief of staff. Webb is an investigative journalist who traces networks of money and intelligence. Wolff is a Marxian economist. Diesen is a realist scholar of international

relations, and so is Mearsheimer, the best known of them. Sachs is an economist and long-time adviser to the United Nations.

The AI (Claude, from Anthropic) worked from their own material: interview transcripts, articles, essays, book chapters, about 170 pieces in all.

Step one: find the common ground

The first step is to count which claims are widely held. For each recurring claim, the AI listed which of the sixteen make it in their own material. They agree on far more than I expected: real decisions are made above elected government, crises and wars move wealth upward, and the dollar system is a weapon.

CLAIM	WHO MAKES IT	COUNT
Real decisions are made above elected government	all but Mearsheimer and Sachs	14
Left against right is the wrong way to see politics	Werner, Krainer, Dixon, Fitts, Henningsen, Martenson, Hudson, Norton, Berletic	9
US allies, Europe above all, are being stripped	Werner, Berletic, Dixon, Norton, Henningsen, Hudson, Wilkerson, Diesen, Wolff	9
The dollar system is a weapon, and it is under strain	Werner, Norton, Berletic, Dixon, Henningsen, Martenson, Hudson, Crooke, Wolff, Sachs	10
Crises and wars move wealth upward	Fitts, Dixon, Norton, Henningsen, Martenson, Wilkerson, Wolff, Sachs	8
Finance has come loose from production	Werner, Hudson, Krainer	3

A count shows how widely a claim is held, not whether it is true.

Step two: assemble the pieces

The second step is to fit their explanations together. Each author explains one piece of how US power works, and put together, the pieces form one machine:

- physical energy as the base (Martenson);
- bank credit creation (Werner);
- rent extraction (Hudson);
- ownership through a few asset managers (Dixon);
- the way policy turns income into share value (Fitts);
- extraction abroad (Krainer);
- the dollar system and sanctions (Norton, Hudson);
- enforcement through sanctions, proxies and blockades (Berletic, Fitts, Henningsen);
- the manufacture of consent through media and think tanks (Henningsen);
- accounts that cannot be audited (Fitts);
- a coming digital control layer (Fitts, Werner);
- the cultural cohesion that lets some societies resist (Crooke);
- a covert economy funded off the books (Fitts).

Each author describes one or two pieces well and the others barely. Together they describe a whole.

That is the core claim of this article: these people do not lack ideas, they lack a way to see each other's work side by side. Once it is laid side by side, much of their apparent disagreement turns out to be people describing different floors of the same building.

Where each author stands explains much of this. A realist looks at states, a former banker at credit, an investigative journalist at networks, and most of the sixteen look from more than one side. The chart below sorts the authors by their conclusions, from power in states to power in networks above states, and marks the sides they look from. Where an author stands largely predicts what they conclude. So each author is most reliable on the side they know best, and least reliable when judging the whole from it. Mearsheimer shows convincingly that the Iran war failed the country; whether it paid anyone inside the country is a question his vantage point does not ask.



Six vantage points on US power, and how much of each author's work is seen from each (a bigger dot means more). Authors are sorted by their conclusions, from power in states (blue) to power in networks above states (orange). The weights are my judgement from each author's background and texts; the reason for each is on the [charts page](#).

Step three: isolate the real disagreements

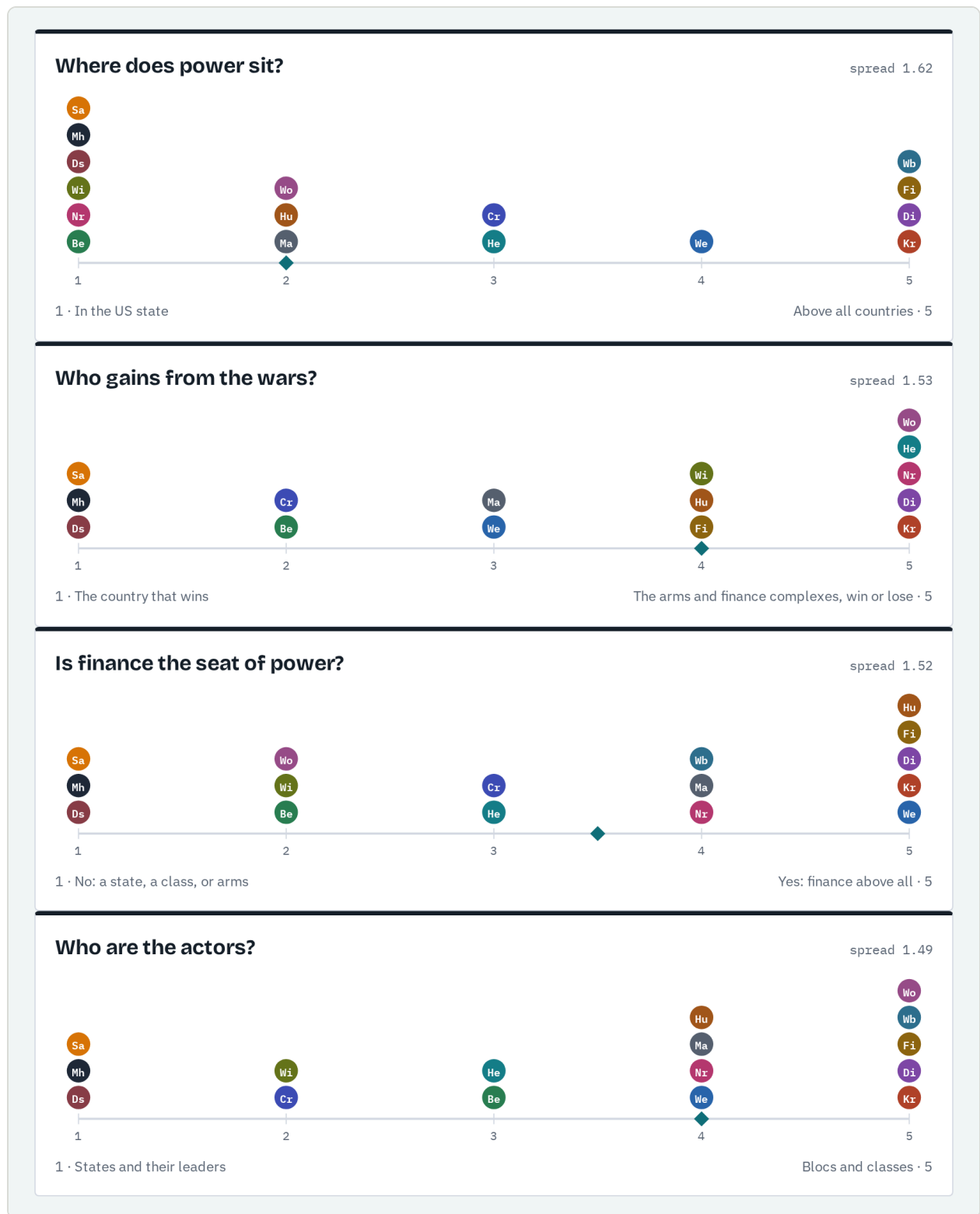
The third step is to find what they actually disagree about. It comes down to two questions.

Who is at the top? Krainer describes a "monolithic and ruthless conspiracy". Dixon says the opposite: "This is systemic. There is no one on top. It's not an organized cabal." Norton and Wolff describe a ruling class acting largely in the open. Diesen needs no ruler at all: a declining power behaves predictably because of its position. Mearsheimer and Sachs look to governments and the lobbies that press on them. Mearsheimer, with Stephen Walt, wrote the best-known case that the Israel lobby steers US policy in the Middle East. Sachs explains the

Iran war through two leaders, Trump and Netanyahu, and the religious nationalists around them.

What is the remedy? One camp wants strong sovereign states to discipline finance (Krainer, Hudson, Norton, Berletic and others), and Mearsheimer and Sachs also put their hope in states. Another wants decentralisation and personal exit (Werner, Fitts, Dixon, Martenson). Each camp's remedy is the other's main fear: the first sees a strong state as protection, the second sees it as the builder of a digital control system. Wolff offers a third way: make firms democratic from the inside, as worker cooperatives.

To make this visible, the AI scored each author from 1 to 5 on thirteen questions, and attached the author's own words to every score. A score without a quote was not allowed.



The four most divisive of the thirteen questions: where power sits, who gains from the wars, whether finance is the seat of power, and who the actors are.

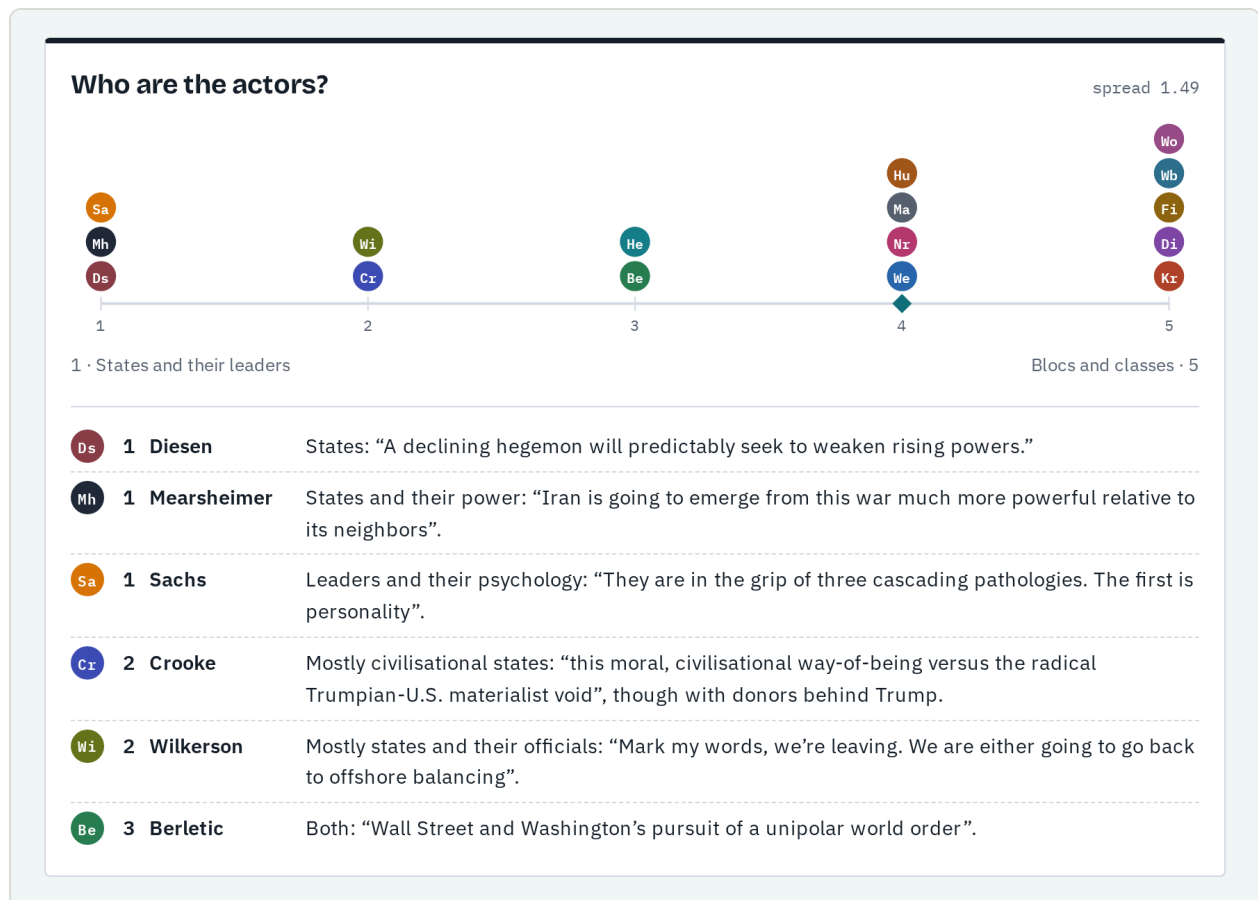
Step four: fix the concepts

The fourth step is to check the concepts behind the questions, because a badly framed question hides the answer. This turned out to be the most useful step.

Early versions of the charts asked "Is the US empire winning or losing?" That question quietly assumes that countries are the actors and that wars are won or lost by countries. Several of the authors think that way. Diesen and Mearsheimer, the realists, do, and so does Sachs. So does Wilkerson, the military man, and often Crooke. When a policy hurts the country that pursues it, they find it puzzling. Diesen on Europe's policy: "For me, it is completely irrational. It doesn't make any sense."

Others reject that frame entirely. Dixon: "America is not a country; it is a series of companies and a financial industrial complex." Wolff describes government as the arena where "clumps" of capitalists bargain. On this view the puzzle disappears. A policy can be irrational for a country and perfectly rational for whoever profits from it.

So we changed the question. "Is the US empire winning or losing?" became "Who gains from the wars?", and a new question was added: "Who are the actors, states or blocs?" The answers spread out sharply, from Diesen, Mearsheimer and Sachs at one end to Dixon, Fitts, Webb, Wolff and Krainer at the other. Wolff put the bloc view in one line: "Wars accelerate contracts to replace used-up arms and thereby profit military-industrial complexes."



States and leaders at one end, blocs and classes at the other, with the first six authors' reasons in their own words. All sixteen reasons, for every question, are on the [charts page](#).

The same shift exposes everyday language. For example, when people say "this war cost us trillions", they get two words wrong. The word "us" is wrong because there is no single payer. The money goes to the arms makers, their shareholders and their employees, spread on purpose across "military bases in all 50 states", as Wolff puts it, so that every member of Congress has a stake. For them the war is income. The word "cost" is misleading because the money is not taken out of anyone's savings: the US borrows it, and because the dollar is the world's reserve currency, investors everywhere keep lending, and the debt is rolled over and rarely paid down. The real costs fall elsewhere: on the people the war kills, the missiles it burns, and the interest future taxpayers will carry.

Step five: map who sits with whom

The fifth step is to see who is close to whom. Measuring the distances between the authors' scores shows two camps.

- **One camp trusts states:** Norton, Hudson and Berletic, with Henningsen, Crooke, Wilkerson, Wolff, Diesen, Mearsheimer and Sachs nearby.
- **The other places power in networks above countries:** Werner, Fitts, Martenson and Webb, with Dixon further out.
- **A third line separates** those who think in countries (Diesen, Mearsheimer, Sachs, Wilkerson, Crooke) from everyone else.
- **The three academics are the tightest cluster:** Diesen, Mearsheimer and Sachs make up the three closest pairs in the set.

Who sits with whom

	We	Kr	Be	Di	Fi	Nr	He	Ma	Hu	Cr	Wi	Ds	Wb	Wo	Mh	Sa
We	·	1.3	1.5	1.4	0.8	1.9	1.6	0.7	1.3	1.2	1.3	1.8	1.2	1.4	2.4	2.0
Kr	1.3	·	1.8	1.3	1.7	1.5	1.4	1.9	1.1	1.6	2.0	2.3	1.8	1.6	2.8	2.5
Be	1.5	1.8	·	2.4	2.1	0.9	1.4	1.8	0.9	0.9	1.3	1.0	2.3	1.3	1.6	1.4
Di	1.4	1.3	2.4	·	1.2	2.2	1.8	1.5	1.8	2.3	2.1	2.8	1.6	1.6	2.7	3.2
Fi	0.8	1.7	2.1	1.2	·	2.3	1.8	1.3	1.6	1.8	1.9	2.3	0.7	1.4	2.7	2.6
Nr	1.9	1.5	0.9	2.2	2.3	·	1.5	1.8	0.7	1.6	1.4	1.4	2.4	1.1	2.1	1.8
He	1.6	1.4	1.4	1.8	1.8	1.5	·	1.3	1.5	0.8	1.3	1.4	1.9	1.1	1.4	1.4
Ma	0.7	1.9	1.8	1.5	1.3	1.8	1.3	·	1.7	1.3	1.0	1.8	1.3	1.2	1.7	1.4
Hu	1.3	1.1	0.9	1.8	1.6	0.7	1.5	1.7	·	1.2	1.6	1.6	2.0	1.3	2.2	2.0
Cr	1.2	1.6	0.9	2.3	1.8	1.6	0.8	1.3	1.2	·	1.1	0.9	2.0	1.4	1.3	1.1
Wi	1.3	2.0	1.3	2.1	1.9	1.4	1.3	1.0	1.6	1.1	·	1.0	2.6	0.8	1.2	0.9
Ds	1.8	2.3	1.0	2.8	2.3	1.4	1.4	1.8	1.6	0.9	1.0	·	2.9	1.3	0.5	0.5
Wb	1.2	1.8	2.3	1.6	0.7	2.4	1.9	1.3	2.0	2.0	2.6	2.9	·	1.9	3.0	3.0
Wo	1.4	1.6	1.3	1.6	1.4	1.1	1.1	1.2	1.3	1.4	0.8	1.3	1.9	·	1.8	1.6
Mh	2.4	2.8	1.6	2.7	2.7	2.1	1.4	1.7	2.2	1.3	1.2	0.5	3.0	1.8	·	0.5
Sa	2.0	2.5	1.4	3.2	2.6	1.8	1.4	1.4	2.0	1.1	0.9	0.5	3.0	1.6	0.5	·

Closest pairs: Diesen and Mearsheimer (0.50), Mearsheimer and Sachs (0.50), Diesen and Sachs (0.55).

Furthest pairs: Dixon and Sachs (3.18), Webb and Sachs (3.00), Webb and Mearsheimer (3.00).

Average distance between every pair of authors. Sachs and Dixon are the furthest apart; Diesen, Mearsheimer and Sachs are the closest.

Who is on the margin

Di Dixon

1.77

What is the remedy? 1 against the group's 4, toward "Decentralise and exit"

Boycott and exit: "If you want to boycott BlackRock, you have to own it in self custody."

Where does power sit? 5 against the group's 2, toward "Above all countries"

Asset managers and sovereign wealth funds: "we are in the asset stripping phase and the money's moving east."

Is the Iran war aimed at China? 1 against the group's 3.5, toward "No"

Not a war on China; before it began he said "Iran has already been regime changed and the IRGC are completely on board".

Is the multipolar bloc a different system? 4 against the group's 1.5, toward "No, the same capital's next home"

"BlackRock wants to split the world up into a multipolar world order. That's the next empire." Sovereign states can still use their own resources.

How coordinated is the power? 1 against the group's 3, toward "Incentives; no one directing"

"There is no one on top. It's not an organized cabal."

Israel: a separate power, or part of the machinery? 1 against the group's 3, toward "Part of the machinery: a proxy and forward base"

A proxy: "if you want to do something that's really, really illegal, like a genocide or ethnic cleansing, then use your Israeli proxy".

What did they expect from Trump? 2 against the group's 4, toward "A real break"

Expected peace seven weeks before the war: "I think Iran has already been regime changed."

Wb Webb

1.72

Is the multipolar bloc a different system? 5 against the group's 1.5, toward "No, the same capital's next home"

One system: Pizarro's "transideological corporation", with Western firms "merging and/ or forging significant agreements or joint ventures" with Eastern state firms.

Where does power sit? 5 against the group's 2, toward "Above all countries"

"A world system of financial control in private hands", run through public-private partnerships.

How coordinated is the power? 5 against the group's 3, toward "One deliberate plan"

"A handful of men with bottomless pockets who were willing to wait decades."

What is the remedy? 2 against the group's 4, toward "Decentralise and exit"

Exposure, with no personal programme in what I read; "The decentralization theater... is masking the greatest centralization of power in history".

Mh Mearsheimer

1.60

Who gains from the wars? 1 against the group's 4, toward "The country that wins"

Framed as a contest between states: "it's just very important to understand that Iran has won this war".

Who are the actors? 1 against the group's 4, toward "States and their leaders"

States and their power: "Iran is going to emerge from this war much more powerful relative to its neighbors".

Is finance the seat of power? 1 against the group's 3.5, toward "No: a state, a class, or arms"

Power belongs to states: "spheres of influence are geographical regions that great powers dominate".

Israel: a separate power, or part of the machinery? 5 against the group's 3, toward "A separate power steering US policy"

With Walt: "the thrust of US policy in the region derives almost entirely from domestic politics", above all the Israel lobby.

The three authors furthest from the group, with the reason for each large gap in their own words: Dixon, then Webb and Mearsheimer. All sixteen are on the [charts page](#).

Step six: test the explanations against facts

The sixth step matters most. Agreement is not proof, especially among people chosen for a shared outlook, so the authors' claims are checked in five ways that do not depend on counting heads: their forecasts against what happened, their models against real cases, their summaries against the documents they cite, their explanations against tests that could prove them wrong, and the competing explanations of the Iran war against the facts.

Forecasts. The authors who studied written plans and the structure of power forecast the Iran war better than those who studied Trump's personality. The attack of 28 February 2026 made that checkable, because fourteen of the sixteen had said something about it before and after. Some got it right:

- Wilkerson, in November 2024: "I'm worried that we might be walking into a war that we cannot walk away from because of Netanyahu."
- Diesen, in March 2025, that Iran "would hit back in a massive way".

Some did not. Dixon said in January 2026 that Iran had "already been regime changed" and that peace was coming, seven weeks before the war.

Cases. A real collision between two blocs shows the bloc model at work. In an October 2026 interview Wolff described farmers, squeezed by diesel prices, asking Trump to ban diesel exports, and the refiners telling him: "We have been your loyal supporters. We don't want this." Trump was caught in the middle: "One group of his supporters want it, another group of his supporters don't want it." The ban was dropped; the farmers got a release of European reserves. One case proves little, but it is what the model predicts: when blocs collide, policy stalls, and the better-organised one wins.

Documents. When an author cites a document, the AI read the document itself. One example is a 2009 Brookings paper, "Which Path to Persia?", cited by Berletic, which discusses deniability openly. One option it lays out is to let Israel strike Iran, so that criticism and retaliation would be "deflected away from the United States and onto Israel". In other words, US planners discussed arranging a war the US wanted so that Israel would take the blame. The paper thought this would be hard to sell, since the planes and much of the money are American, but the option was on paper. That matters for the authors who say the Iran war was fought only for Israel: if putting the blame on Israel was part of the planning, then Israel looking responsible is exactly what the plan would produce, and proves nothing on its own.

Hypotheses. Each competing explanation comes with tests that could prove it wrong, and one has already partly failed. The AI collected ten explanations, ranging from a hidden directing hand and a ruling class acting in the open to a nexus of competing interest blocs, energy

dominance, a war for Israel's own aims, land against sea, and a plan that fails on contact with reality. Each comes with the authors whose material supports it, the authors whose material cuts against it, and its tests. One holds that finance can move east while the arms industry stays rooted in the United States. Its first test was "foreign holdings of US Treasuries keep falling", and the data split it in two:

- Central banks outside the West are cutting their Treasuries and buying gold, exactly as predicted. As of August 2026, China's central bank had bought gold for 22 months in a row.
- Total foreign holdings reached a record in June 2026, as private buyers bought more.

The hypothesis is now marked "mixed". That is the value of a test that can fail.

H1. A nexus of interests

Question 4: is anyone hidden at the top?

The US state is shared by interest blocs (finance, arms, energy, technology, the Israel lobby, media and think tanks). A policy happens when enough blocs want it and none strong enough objects; finance owns and funds the others.

PROPOSED BY · DIXON, HENNINGSEN, HUDSON AND WOLFF, EACH IN PART

Fits the material of: Di He Hu Wo

Cuts against: Kr Wb Cx Nx Mh

EVIDENCE

Dixon's shared ownership, Henningsen's blocs, Hudson's choke points, Wolff's "clumps" of capitalists bargaining over the state.

OBJECTION

Krainer and Webb see one directing group; Norton sees one class; Crooke sees a project behind the blocs.

WHAT WOULD TEST IT

- Policy stalls or reverses where blocs collide
- The Israel lobby against finance or energy

WHERE IT STANDS

One case fits: the diesel collision (October 2026), where the oil bloc beat agriculture. The harder test has not occurred.

One of the ten, a nexus of interests, with its supporters, objection and tests. All ten are on the [charts page](#) and in the [full synthesis](#), each with a current status, so they can be checked as events unfold.

Weighing the evidence. Counting authors cannot settle a question like what the Iran war is for. So we borrowed a method from intelligence analysis, Richards Heuer's analysis of competing hypotheses. You list facts, not opinions: documents, public data, and events the authors report. You mark each fact as fitting, contradicting, or irrelevant to each explanation.

The winner is the explanation with the fewest solid facts against it, not the most in its favour, because most facts fit several stories at once. Facts that a capable actor could stage for appearances are flagged, and the ranking is computed with and without them.

Five explanations went into the first grid. Two have no fact against them at all: a war against China's corridors, and a war for profit for the arms, energy and finance blocs. That is partly a weakness of the method: an explanation that predicts little is hard to contradict. Reading the war as a blunder comes next, with one fact against it: its targets, such as China's new railway through Iran, were chosen strategically. A war for US energy dominance and a war for Israel's own aims tie, each with one solid fact against it. For energy dominance it is Europe's record purchases of Russian gas; for Israel's own aims it is the Brookings deflection option described above.

The size of the lobbies also points away from Israel as the main driver. By OpenSecrets' count, the defense industry spent about \$150 million on federal lobbying in the 2024 cycle, and the oil and gas industry spends about as much each year. AIPAC spent about \$3.3 million in 2024, tens of times less; its weight is in election money instead, about \$95 million on the 2024 elections with its super PAC. Yet the arms and energy lobbies rarely make the news. Several authors see Israel not as a separate player but as part of the machinery. Dixon puts it bluntly: for what is "really, really illegal", use "your Israeli proxy".

But a war can have a purpose and still fail. Wolff's own summary has both halves: its "goal was to reverse the decline of the US empire; its result was the opposite." So a second grid asked whether the plan is working, and here the facts are mostly public data:

- at least ten US radars destroyed in the first two weeks, four of them guiding THAAD batteries;
- Patriot interceptor stocks down by about two-thirds and THAAD by over a third, with at least three years to rebuild them;
- THAAD interceptors pulled from South Korea and Patriots diverted from Ukraine;
- aircraft carriers resupplied from Diego Garcia, 2,200 miles away, after the Bahrain base was hit.

"On track" had by far the most facts against it. "Failing" and "profit either way" both fit, and both can be true: an arms industry built for profit can enrich its contractors while the plan for dominance fails. The one solid fact against "failing" is that the US share of Europe's LNG imports keeps rising. The energy-sales part of the plan is working even if the military part is not.

The gaps in the first grid are small, and every mark is a judgement. That is why each "against" is shown with its reason, so a reader can disagree with a specific mark instead of with the whole conclusion.

2. Is the plan working?						
	EXPLANATION	FROM	WEIGHTED AGAINST	FACTS AGAINST	FACTS THAT FIT	AGAINST, STAGED FACTS DROPPED
1	Profit either way: the outcome does not matter to those the war pays	Hudson, Wolff; the 'Who gains from the wars?' axis	0.0	0	10	0.0
2	Failing on contact: new weapons, a hollowed-out industrial base, a war that will not stay short	H11: Crooke, Wilkerson, Hudson, Wolff	1.0	1	19	1.0
3	On track: the plan is advancing as designed	H2 read as succeeding; Jiang Xueqin (cited for his forecasts)	11.8	13	6	11.8
FACT				ON TRACK	FAILING	PROFIT EITHER WAY
G1. Iran destroyed at least ten US radars in the war's first two weeks, including four AN/TPY-2 radars that guide THAAD batteries. HIGH ABC News satellite imagery review (March 2026) Against "On track": Blinding the missile shield at the outset is not a plan going to schedule.				against	fits	fits
G2. Iran's fastest missiles got through Israeli air defences. MEDIUM Crooke: "Iranian high-end missiles flying at speeds above Mach Four are proving largely impervious to Israeli air defences" Against "On track": Defences that do not stop the main threat are not part of a plan going well.				against	fits	fits
G3. Killing the Supreme Leader rallied support for the Iranian state instead of toppling it. MEDIUM Crooke: "it led instead to massive outpourings of support for the Islamic Republic" Against "On track": The decapitation was meant to bring the state down.				against	fits	.
G4. US interceptor stocks fell steeply: Patriot from about 2,330 before the war to 760–830, THAAD from 452 to 234–278 even after some resupply. HIGH CSIS estimates, reported by ABC News and Arab News (2026) Against "On track": A plan cannot run on munitions it is using up faster than it makes them.				against	fits	fits
G5. Replacing the Patriot, THAAD and Tomahawk stocks will take at least three years; Patriot output is about 600 a year. HIGH CSIS; Pentagon production figures (2026) Against "On track": Only a short war fits stocks that take years to rebuild, and this one was not short.				against	fits	fits

The ranking for "Is the plan working?" and the first five of its 22 facts, each marked against each explanation. The ranking counts the solid facts against, not the facts in favour. Both grids, with every fact and its source, are on the [charts page](#).

Step seven: check every quote, and read people properly

The last step checks the synthesis itself, first mechanically, then by human judgement. The AI made mistakes, and rereading its own work did not catch them. One was telling: it credited me with ideas that were already in the authors' work. What caught the mistakes was a check it built and ran: a ledger. Every author's texts were saved in one folder per author. A short program checked every quotation in the document against those texts, and checked every "seven of the sixteen" count against the list of names. It flagged anything it could not find. By the end, more than 400 quotations had been checked, over 300 of them long enough to verify word for word, and none remained unmatched. Every one of the 191 scores on the charts carries a quote that passed the same check.

One popular commentator's interview made four striking claims. Each had a real core, and each was stretched: meetings with separatists turned into operatives stirring up separatism, a basing agreement into de facto control, two million dollars into thirty. The pattern is common: a theory first, then facts shaped to fit it. Checking each claim against the record is the only defence.

The lesson for anyone using AI on serious material: the synthesis is cheap now. The checking is the work. An AI that writes fluently and quotes freely will drift from its sources. A dull, mechanical check catches what a careful rereading misses.

Some of the most useful corrections came from me, because I had listened to these people for years.

Martenson often sounds baffled on camera, about markets or oil prices. The AI read that as uncertainty. I did not. In his own writing he is plain: "the price of oil is so heavily manipulated at this point that veteran commodities traders and portfolio managers like Jeff Currie are throwing in the towel in exasperation." In one interview he does both in a single breath. He calls it "what I will politely call shenanigans", then says the markets "were clearly manipulated". People who depend on video platforms often speak more carefully on camera than on the page. An honest synthesis has to read both.

It also took a lot of coaching to keep the AI on the rails. Left to itself, it read events the way they are presented. It took official statements at face value, when everyone involved has reasons to lie. It did not see that an empire which needs its population on its side also needs plausible deniability, so a war can be made to look like someone else's. And it judged each move on its own, when the players are willing to sacrifice many pawns to win a queen.

This is where a human and an AI work well together. The AI reads everything; the human knows how these people talk.

The limits

I want to be clear about what this does not show.

- **It does not prove that their picture is right.** These sixteen were chosen for a shared outlook, so part of their agreement was built in.
- **Some of them share sources.** Where two authors rely on the same document or witness, their agreement counts once, not twice.
- **The scores are judgements.** They rest on the authors' own words, but someone decided which words to use.
- **One test case.** The facts were tested against the Iran war. Ukraine, which several of the authors discuss as much, would be the natural second test.
- **Reading time was uneven.** Some authors publish mostly behind paywalls or in video, so they were read less.

What it does show is narrower and, I think, more useful. Where a group of serious, independent thinkers converges, the agreement is worth taking seriously. Where they split, the split can usually be reduced to one or two precise questions. And those questions can often be tested.

What it means

A decade ago, a project like this would have needed a team of researchers for months. It took a few days of conversation, a folder of transcripts and a program that checks quotes. The hard part has shifted. Producing a synthesis is now easy; producing one you can trust is the work.

Laid side by side like this, independent thinkers could start to work as a team: not by agreeing on everything, but by seeing where they already agree and where they differ, and why.

For more detail: the full charts page, including the evidence grids, is at christiancadieux.github.io/fourteen-thinkers/author-axes.html, and the full written synthesis is at github.com/christiancadieux/fourteen-thinkers/blob/main/synthesis.md. The saved source texts and the program that checks every quote are on GitHub at github.com/christiancadieux/fourteen-thinkers.

